The Production and Control of Representations in Artificial Intelligence

Research II — A Conceptual Architecture, Authority Structure, Representation Lifecycle, and Research Protocol

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Abstract

Artificial intelligence systems increasingly mediate the production, transformation, selection, distribution, and reception of representations encountered by individuals. This research program, designated Research II, examines the structural relations through which such representations are constituted before they reach a recipient, treating representation itself as the central analytical object rather than treating the model, the platform, or the user in isolation. The program's central question is who produces the representations a recipient encounters through AI systems, who controls their formation, availability, and appearance, and who consumes them. This question is structural: it does not presuppose that production, control, and consumption are each located in a single entity. The program specifies four foundational documents. A Conceptual Architecture (adopted, version 0.2) distinguishes five functional units — Producer, Model/Generative System, Platform/Controller, Distribution Interface, and Recipient/Consumer — defined by function rather than by institutional identity, together with five provisional configuration patterns describing how these functions may concentrate, separate, or distribute across entities. An Authority Structure (pending adoption, version 0.1) distinguishes five authority types — Production, Transformation, Selection, Distribution, and Interpretive Authority — and establishes that authority is analytically distinct from function. A Representation Lifecycle (pending adoption, version 0.1) traces six structural stages through which a representation may pass, specifying a canonical path and five structurally distinct alternative paths, together with the conditions under which the lifecycle may be interrupted at each stage. A Research Questions document (pending adoption, version 0.1) formulates research questions across four families — conceptual, authority, lifecycle, and boundary questions — including an explicit boundary question concerning the relation between Research II and a separate, methodologically independent research program (Research I) on epistemic discipline in human-AI interaction. No empirical work has been performed under this protocol. The literature review, the methodological scope, and the selection of systems for analysis remain to be determined following adoption of the four foundational documents. The program's commitments are therefore reported as specified, not as established: this manuscript presents an architecture and a research protocol, not findings.

Keywords: *Representational Authority; AI-Mediated Systems; Platform Governance; Production and Control; Distribution Interfaces; Interpretive Authority; Representation Lifecycle; Structural Research Architecture; Research Protocol.*

Research status: *Architecture Specification Stage* · ***Researcher configuration:*** *Independent individual researcher*
Empirical status: *No systems examined; no data collected* · ***Document status:*** *Conceptual Architecture v0.2 adopted; Authority Structure, Representation Lifecycle, and Research Questions each at v0.1, pending adoption*

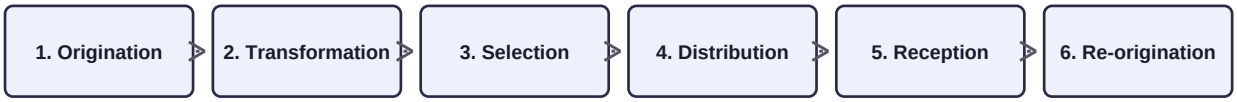
Figure 1



The Five Functional Units of the Conceptual Architecture

Figure 1. The five functions are analytical, not presumptive organizations or technical components. A single entity may perform more than one function; a function may be jointly performed by several entities. The architecture does not assume a fixed one-to-one mapping between functions and owners.

Figure 2



The Six Stages of the Representation Lifecycle — Canonical Path

Figure 2. The canonical path, in which a representation passes through all six stages in sequence with one entity performing each function, is analytically clean but empirically rare; it serves as a reference point rather than a normative description. Section 5 specifies five structurally distinct alternative paths.

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1. Introduction

1.1 Representations Mediated by AI Systems

Artificial intelligence systems increasingly stand between material — text, data, structured queries, multimodal signals — and the representations that individuals ultimately encounter. A generated summary, an answer to a question, a ranked list of results, or a synthesized explanation is a representation: something constituted, shaped, and made available, rather than a raw transmission of pre-existing content.

The constitution of such representations is rarely attributable to a single, isolable act. Material may originate with one party, be transformed by a generative system controlled by another, be filtered or ranked under policies set by a third, and be presented through an interface designed by a fourth, before it reaches a recipient who may interpret, accept, reject, or redistribute it.

This research program, designated Research II within a broader independent research effort, treats this chain of functions as the central object of study.

1.2 The Central Question

Who produces the representations that a recipient encounters through AI systems, who controls their formation, availability, and appearance, and who consumes them?

This question is deliberately structural rather than accusatory or normative. It does not presuppose that production, control, and consumption are each located in a single entity, that any one party necessarily dominates the chain, or that current arrangements are illegitimate. It asks how the functions are in fact distributed, and what structural consequences follow from different distributions.

1.3 Representation as the Unit of Analysis

The program's unit of analysis is not the model, the platform, or the user considered in isolation, but the representation itself and the chain of functions through which it is constituted before reaching a recipient.

This choice of unit has a direct methodological consequence: the architecture that follows is built around functions — origination, transformation, governance, presentation, reception — rather than around named technologies or named companies. The same functional architecture is intended to apply whether a given system concentrates all five functions in one organization or distributes them across many.

1.4 Program Structure and Scope of This Manuscript

Research II is specified through four foundational documents, developed in sequence and adopted individually:

1. A **Conceptual Architecture**, defining the functional units and their relations (adopted, version 0.2).
2. An **Authority Structure**, defining the kinds of authority that may be exercised over a representation (version 0.1, pending adoption).
3. A **Representation Lifecycle**, tracing the stages through which a representation may pass (version 0.1, pending adoption).
4. A set of **Research Questions**, formulated on the basis of the three preceding documents (version 0.1, pending adoption).

This manuscript consolidates the four documents into a single research protocol. It does not add new architectural commitments beyond what the four source documents specify, and it does not report empirical findings. Methodological scope — whether the program's questions will be examined

analytically, empirically, or through a combination of the two — is explicitly deferred to a later determination, following adoption of the architecture (Section 7.2).

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2. Literature Positioning

> ***Status:*** *Pending — a structured literature review has not yet been conducted.*

Consistent with the research program's general discipline of not presenting unverified claims of originality, this document does not yet situate the Conceptual Architecture, Authority Structure, or Representation Lifecycle against specific prior literatures in platform studies, algorithmic governance, media sociology, or science and technology studies.

The subsequent literature review will need to examine, at minimum, several adjacent traditions without presuming the proposed architecture is unprecedented in each:

- Platform governance and content moderation research, which examines selection and distribution authority in social and search platforms.
- Media sociology and the political economy of communication, which has long examined production and control as potentially distinct functions.
- Algorithmic accountability and recommender-system research, which examines ranking, filtering, and interpretive framing as distinct technical operations.
- Actor-network and infrastructure studies, which offer vocabulary for distributed, non-unitary agency across technical and organizational components.
- Human-AI interaction research on trust, reliance, and interpretation of AI-generated content, which bears on the Recipient's interpretive position described in Section 5.6.

No claim of conceptual originality for the five-function architecture, the five-authority structure, or the six-stage lifecycle is made in advance of this review. Their value, and their relationship to existing frameworks in the literatures above, is treated as an open question to be examined rather than assumed.

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3. Conceptual Architecture

Status: Adopted, version 0.2. This section consolidates the adopted Conceptual Architecture document.

3.1 Purpose and Non-Commitments

The Conceptual Architecture specifies the analytical units used throughout the program and the functional relations between them. It does not classify the program as theoretical, analytical, or empirical; does not specify platforms, venues, or publication formats; does not fix the methodology of future studies; and does not adopt pre-committed conclusions about who controls what. It establishes only the analytical vocabulary and the relations between its units.

3.2 Functional Units, Not Entities

The architecture distinguishes five functional units, defined by function rather than by institutional identity, ownership, or technical component.

#	Functional Unit	Function
1	Producer	Originates or supplies the material from which the representation is constituted.
2	Model / Generative System	Transforms inputs into a representation.
3	Platform / Controller	Governs the conditions of production, presentation, and availability.
4	Distribution Interface	Determines how the representation reaches and appears to the recipient.
5	Recipient / Consumer	Receives the representation and engages with it.

A single entity may perform more than one function. Two or more entities may jointly perform a single function. A function may be distributed across entities, or may be internal to a single technical system.

Foundational assumption (negative): *Research II does not assume that each function has a distinct owner, nor that any one function subsumes the others.*

This negative assumption is itself an object of investigation. The program's first task is not to assign owners to functions, but to examine the patterns of separation, merger, and distribution that actually occur.

3.3 Functional Descriptions

Producer

Responsible for originating or supplying the semantic, informational, or representational material from which a representation is constituted, through direct authorship, source selection, framing, or the provision of inputs that materially shape the resulting representation. Providing an input does not by itself establish authorship of the resulting representation; this relationship remains an analytical question. The Producer is defined by the act of origination or material supply, not by ownership of the technical system.

Model / Generative System

Performs the transformation of inputs into a representation. Its function is technical and operational. It is not by itself a Producer unless it also originates the representation, and not by itself a Controller unless it also governs the conditions of production.

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Platform / Controller

Governs the conditions under which representations are produced, presented, and made available, including policy on what may be produced, what may be displayed, ordering, ranking, filtering, availability, access, and retention. It is defined by the exercise of governance over conditions, not by ownership of the Model.

Distribution Interface

Determines how the representation reaches the recipient and how it appears — a technical interface, a policy-driven interface (ranking, sorting, filtering, visibility rules), or an integration of both. It is not by itself a Controller unless it also exercises governance over conditions, but it may be the site where control is materially enacted.

Recipient / Consumer

Receives the representation and engages with it through interpretation, evaluation, acceptance, rejection, further use, or further distribution. The program treats the Recipient as an active participant whose interpretive authority is itself one of the elements under examination, not as a passive endpoint.

Role Transition and Feedback

A Recipient may also perform the Producer function within the same system or across subsequent representational cycles; reception may lead to reinterpretation, modification, recombination, or the production of a new representation. Such transitions do not collapse the Recipient and Producer functions — they indicate that functional roles may change across stages or cycles, and that a single entity may occupy different functional positions over time.

3.4 Relations Between Functions

Relation	Description
Origination → Transformation	The Producer's output feeds the Model / Generative System as input.
Transformation → Presentation	The Model's output is presented through the Distribution Interface.
Governance over Origination	The Platform / Controller may constrain what the Producer can originate.
Governance over Transformation	The Platform / Controller may constrain how the Model can transform.
Governance over Presentation	The Platform / Controller may constrain what the Distribution Interface presents.
Presentation → Reception	The Distribution Interface's output reaches the Recipient.
Reception → Re-origination	A recipient may transform, reinterpret, or reuse a received representation to originate a new representa

These relations are analytical, not temporal or technical in themselves; their operational sequencing is specified by the Representation Lifecycle (Section 5).

3.5 Patterns of Functional Configuration

The architecture does not prescribe a fixed configuration of the five functions. It distinguishes five provisional configuration patterns.

Pattern	Description
Concentrated Configuration	Multiple functions are performed by a single entity.
Partially Integrated Configuration	Two or more functions are combined within an entity, while others remain distributed.
Functionally Separated Configuration	Each function is performed by a distinct entity or operational component.

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Pattern	Description
Distributed Configuration	A function is jointly performed by multiple entities, or its execution is distributed across components.
Hybrid Configuration	Different functions exhibit different degrees of concentration, separation, or distribution.

These patterns are provisional analytical categories, not an exhaustive taxonomy. Actual configurations must be identified through examination of the systems under study.

3.6 Foundational Distinctions

The architecture preserves five distinctions as analytically non-collapsible, each holding even where the two sides empirically coincide in a given system:

1. **Production ≠ Control** — the authority to originate a representation is not the same as the authority to govern its production or presentation.
2. **Control ≠ Distribution** — the authority to govern conditions is not the same as the authority to determine the presentation interface.
3. **Distribution ≠ Reception** — the interface that presents a representation is not the same as the recipient who receives it; interpretive engagement is not determined by the interface alone.
4. **Function ≠ Owner** — no function is assumed to correspond to a specific entity; functions are analytical, owners are empirical.
5. **Governance ≠ Execution** — the authority to establish or modify conditions is distinct from the operational execution of those conditions.

3.7 What This Architecture Excludes

The Conceptual Architecture deliberately does not classify the program as theoretical, empirical, or methodological; specify platforms, venues, or publication formats; adopt pre-committed conclusions about the distribution of authority; assume that any single entity controls the full chain; assume the Recipient is passive, the Model a neutral transformation, the Platform external to the Model, or the Distribution Interface technical only; or assume a single direction of representational flow across cycles. These exclusions are commitments to keep the analytical frame open until the Authority Structure and Representation Lifecycle are specified.

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4. Authority Structure

Status: Version 0.1, pending adoption. Depends on the Conceptual Architecture (adopted, v0.2).

4.1 Purpose

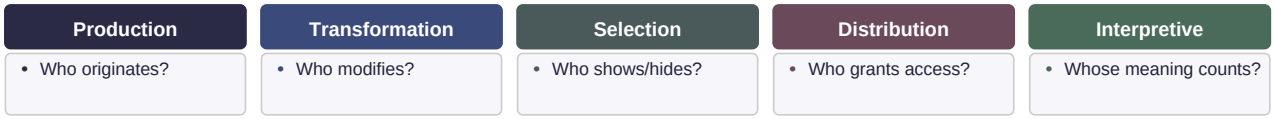
This section specifies the kinds of authority that may be exercised over a representation. It distinguishes five authority types, defines each, specifies its object, and identifies the structural questions that follow from its exercise. It does not assign authority to specific entities, and does not assume that any entity exercises all five authorities, nor that the five always appear together.

4.2 The Five Authorities

Authority	Object	Central Question
Production Authority	The representation as originated	Who has the authority to originate this representation?
Transformation Authority	The representation as modified	Who has the authority to modify or reshape this representation?
Selection Authority	The representation as presented	Who has the authority to decide what is shown and what is not?
Distribution Authority	The representation as available	Who has the authority to determine access, reach, and retention?
Interpretive Authority	The representation as interpreted	Who has the authority to present a particular interpretation as the accepted o

Foundational assumption (negative): *Research II does not assume that the five authorities are concentrated in a single entity, nor that they always appear in the same configuration.*

Figure 3



The Five Authority Types and Their Central Questions

Figure 3. The five authorities are analytically distinct; a single entity may exercise more than one, and an authority may be jointly exercised or distributed across entities.

4.3 Authority Descriptions

Production Authority

The authority to originate a representation — to constitute the material from which it is formed — exercised through direct authorship, source selection, framing, or input provision that materially shapes the resulting representation. Providing an input does not by itself confer Production Authority over the output; this relation is an analytical question, not an assumption.

Transformation Authority

The authority to modify or reshape a representation after origination, exercised through editing, rephrasing, re-ranking, re-contextualizing, or re-generating from source. Not the same as Production Authority: a representation may be produced by one entity and transformed, with or without authorization, by another.

Selection Authority

The authority to decide what is shown and what is not, exercised through inclusion, exclusion, prioritization, ordering, or filtering. Operates on the set of representations available to a recipient and determines the composition of what the recipient encounters.

Distribution Authority

The authority to determine access, reach, and retention of a representation, exercised through access control, licensing, geographic restriction, temporal availability, or retention policy. Not the same as Selection Authority: a representation may be selected for presentation but restricted in distribution, or distributed broadly without being prominently selected.

Interpretive Authority

The authority to present a particular interpretation of a representation as the accepted one, exercised through framing, contextualization, commentary, classification, or designation of an interpretation as authoritative. Interpretive Authority is the most structurally delicate of the five: it concerns not what is produced, selected, or distributed, but what is taken to mean.

4.4 Authority Distribution Patterns

Pattern	Description
Consolidated Authority	A single entity exercises all five authorities.
Partially Separated Authority	Some authorities are concentrated, others are distributed.
Fully Separated Authority	Each authority is exercised by a distinct entity.
Distributed Authority	A single authority is jointly exercised by multiple entities, or distributed across components.
Hybrid Distribution	Different authorities exhibit different degrees of concentration, separation, or distribution.

These patterns are provisional analytical starting points, not a taxonomy of actual configurations.

4.5 Relations Between Authorities

The five authorities are not independent; they interact in structurally important ways. The architecture specifies ten pairwise distinctions, of which five are illustrated below; the remaining five follow the same logic.

- **Production** ⊥ **Transformation** — an entity may produce without authority to transform, or transform representations it did not produce.
- **Transformation** ⊥ **Selection** — an entity may transform without deciding whether a representation is shown, or select without modifying.
- **Selection** ⊥ **Distribution** — an entity may select for presentation without controlling broader distribution, or distribute widely without selecting for specific presentation.
- **Distribution** ⊥ **Interpretation** — an entity may distribute without framing interpretation, or frame interpretation without controlling distribution.
- **Production** ⊥ **Interpretation** — an entity may produce without determining interpretation, or interpret a representation it did not produce.

Each pair is analytically separable even where it is empirically joined in a specific system.

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4.6 The Central Structural Question

Which authorities are concentrated, which are separated, and which are distributed — and what structural consequences follow from each configuration?

This question is not answered by the Authority Structure itself; it is the object of the program's subsequent analytical and empirical work. The architecture provides the vocabulary; the program examines the actual distributions.

4.7 Authority and Function

Authority is not the same as function. A function is what is done; an authority is the right to do it. The mapping between the five functions (Section 3.2) and the five authorities is not fixed: a function may be exercised without a corresponding authority (an unauthorized act), an authority may be held without the corresponding function being exercised (a reserved right), and the same function may be authorized by different authorities in different systems. This distinction prevents the architecture from collapsing "who does what" into "who has the right to do what."

4.8 Governance ≠ Execution (Reaffirmed)

The Conceptual Architecture established that governance is not execution. This holds for each authority individually: the authority to establish a rule governing Production, Transformation, Selection, or Distribution is distinct from the authority to execute it. An entity may hold authority to establish rules without holding authority to execute them; another may execute rules without holding authority to establish them.

4.9 What This Document Excludes

The Authority Structure deliberately does not assign the five authorities to specific entities, assume a single distribution pattern, assume that authority and function are aligned, assume authority is always exercised or always visible to the recipient, specify enforcement mechanisms, or adopt a normative stance on which distribution patterns are preferable.

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5. Representation Lifecycle

Status: Version 0.1, pending adoption. Depends on the Conceptual Architecture (adopted, v0.2) and the Authority Structure (v0.1, pending).

5.1 Purpose

This section traces the path of a representation through the five functions and the five authorities. It does not prescribe a single path; it specifies the structural stages through which a representation may pass, and the conditions under which different paths arise.

5.2 The Six Lifecycle Stages

Stage	Description
1. Origination	The representation is constituted from material.
2. Transformation	The representation is modified, reshaped, or regenerated.
3. Selection	The representation is included in or excluded from the presented set.
4. Distribution	The representation is made available (or restricted).
5. Reception	The representation reaches the recipient.
6. Re-origination	The recipient may produce a new representation, entering the lifecycle again.

These stages are analytical, not temporal. A representation may pass through all six or through a subset; the order may vary; some stages may be absent, repeated, or simultaneous.

5.3 The Canonical Path

The canonical path is the path through which a representation passes all six stages in sequence, with one entity performing each function:

Origination → Transformation → Selection → Distribution → Reception → [Re-origination → ...]

This path is analytically clean, empirically rare, and useful as a baseline for comparison. It is a reference point, not a norm.

5.4 Alternative Paths

Five structurally distinct alternative paths are specified.

Merged Path

Multiple stages are performed by the same entity: [Origination + Transformation + Selection + Distribution] → Reception → [Re-origination → ...]. Common in integrated platforms where a single service controls the full chain.

Skipped Transformation

Origination → Selection → Distribution → Reception. Appears when the representation is presented as-is after origination.

Skipped Selection

Origination → Transformation → Distribution → Reception. Appears when the presentation set is not curated, as in unfiltered chronological feeds.

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Distributed Origination

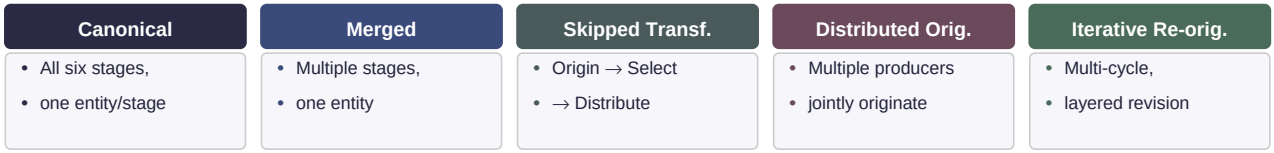
[Producer■ + Producer■ + … + Producer■] → Transformation → … Appears in collaborative, multi-source, or composite representations.

Iterative Re-origination

Origination → … → Reception → Re-origination → Transformation → … → Reception → … Appears in recursively generated, remixed, or chained representations.

These five alternative paths are not exhaustive; they are structurally distinct reference points.

Figure 4



Canonical Path and Five Alternative Paths

Figure 4. The canonical path serves only as an analytical baseline; the five alternative paths are offered as structurally distinct reference points expected to be more empirically common.

5.5 The Lifecycle and Authority

Stage	Authority Typically Exercised
Origination	Production Authority
Transformation	Transformation Authority
Selection	Selection Authority
Distribution	Distribution Authority
Reception	(Recipient's Interpretive Authority)
Re-origination	Production Authority (in a new cycle)

The mapping is typical, not necessary. An authority may be exercised outside its corresponding stage, and a stage may occur without its corresponding authority being fully exercised.

5.6 Structural Breaks in the Lifecycle

The lifecycle may be structurally interrupted at several points, each analytically significant because it reveals where authority is exercised to constrain the chain.

- **Interruption at Origination** — abandonment, restriction before completion, or failure to reach the transformation stage.
- **Interruption at Transformation** — direct presentation without transformation, process failure, or policy-based blocking of transformation.
- **Interruption at Selection** — exclusion from the presented set, sub-threshold ranking, filtering, or suppression.
- **Interruption at Distribution** — access restriction, geographic limitation, temporal unavailability, or retention failure.
- **Interruption at Reception** — failure of the recipient to encounter the representation, recipient disengagement, or structural barriers to access.

5.7 The Recipient's Interpretive Position

Reception is not a passive endpoint. The Recipient's Interpretive Authority (Section 4.3) operates on the representation received and may confirm the representation's framing, contest it, produce an alternative interpretation, or lead to re-origination, returning to the lifecycle. The Recipient's interpretive position is therefore not determined by the earlier stages; it is structurally distinct from them.

5.8 The Lifecycle as Analytical Instrument

The lifecycle is not a description of how representations actually move; it is an instrument for examining which stages are present in a given system, which paths a representation takes, which authorities are exercised at each stage, where structural interruptions occur, and how the Recipient's interpretive authority operates. It is applied to specific systems, not derived from them.

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6. Research Questions

Status: Version 0.1, pending adoption. The questions are formulated, not answered; the methods by which they will be examined are not specified here.

The research questions are organized into four families.

Family	Focus
A. Conceptual	The analytical categories themselves
B. Authority	The distribution and exercise of authority
C. Lifecycle	The paths and interruptions of representations
D. Boundary	The relation to Research I and to methodological scope

Questions in families A–C are foundational to Research II. Questions in family D are boundary questions, classified separately.

6.1 Family A — Conceptual Questions

RQ-A1

Are the five functional units (Producer, Model, Platform, Distribution Interface, Recipient) analytically distinct in actual systems, or do they routinely merge in ways that require a different analytical vocabulary?

RQ-A2

Are the five authority types exercised by distinct entities, or do specific configurations of concentration appear systematically?

RQ-A3

What structural conditions determine whether functions and authorities coincide or diverge?

These questions test the architecture's own categories against the systems it seeks to describe.

6.2 Family B — Authority Questions

1. **RQ-B1.** How is Production Authority distributed across entities in AI-mediated representational systems?
2. **RQ-B2.** How is Transformation Authority distributed, and under what conditions does it diverge from Production Authority?
3. **RQ-B3.** How is Selection Authority distributed, and what criteria govern the selection of representations for presentation?
4. **RQ-B4.** How is Distribution Authority distributed, and what conditions constrain access, reach, and retention?
5. **RQ-B5.** How is Interpretive Authority distributed, and whose interpretations are presented as authoritative?
6. **RQ-B6.** What patterns of authority distribution recur across different systems, and what structural factors explain these patterns?

6.3 Family C — Lifecycle Questions

1. **RQ-C1.** Which lifecycle paths (canonical, merged, skipped, distributed, iterative) appear in practice, and with what frequency?
2. **RQ-C2.** What structural factors determine which path a representation takes?
3. **RQ-C3.** Where do structural interruptions occur, and what do they reveal about the exercise of authority?
4. **RQ-C4.** How do re-origination cycles interact with the lifecycle's earlier stages, and what structural transformations occur across cycles?
5. **RQ-C5.** How does the Recipient's interpretive authority operate on representations that have passed through different lifecycle paths?

6.4 Family D — Boundary Questions

RQ-D1 (Boundary with Research I)

How does the structural distribution of authority over representations affect the recipient's epistemic standards, as examined in Research I (*Epistemic Discipline in the Age of Artificial Intelligence*, Baladi, 2026)?

Status: Classified as a boundary question, not a foundational question of Research II. It examines a potential relation between the two programs without assuming that Research I's findings apply to Research II, or that Research II's findings determine Research I's conclusions. The two programs remain methodologically independent; RQ-D1 concerns their possible intersection, not an integration of the two.

RQ-D2 (Methodological Scope)

What methodological approaches are adequate for examining the questions in families A–C: analytical, empirical, or both?

Status: Deferred until the architecture (Conceptual, Authority, Lifecycle) is adopted. The methodology of Research II is not fixed in advance.

6.5 Priority and Sequencing

Priority	Questions	Rationale
First	RQ-A1, RQ-A2, RQ-A3	Test the architecture's own categories.
Second	RQ-B1–RQ-B6	Operationalize authority distribution.
Third	RQ-C1–RQ-C5	Operationalize the lifecycle.
Later	RQ-D1, RQ-D2	Boundary and methodological questions.

This sequencing reflects the architecture's dependency structure: conceptual questions ground authority questions, authority questions ground lifecycle questions, and boundary/methodological questions follow once the foundational questions are examined.

6.6 What These Questions Do Not Assume

The research questions deliberately do not assume that the five functional units are always distinct, that the five authorities are always separated, that the canonical lifecycle path is normative, that interruptions are failures, that authority and function align, that Research I's findings determine Research II's questions, or that a specific methodology is required.

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7. Relation to Research I and Methodological Scope

7.1 Research I and Research II: Independent Programs

Research I, *Epistemic Discipline in the Age of Artificial Intelligence: A Three-Study Research Protocol* (Baladi, 2026; DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23876902), examines whether repeated interaction with an AI system can change a recipient's standards for interpreting system behavior and accepting its outputs, independently of improvements in the evidential quality of those outputs. Its unit of analysis is the recipient's evolving interpretive standards across repeated interactions with a single system.

Research II examines the structural distribution of production, transformation, selection, distribution, and interpretive authority over representations across the broader chain of functions that produces what a recipient encounters, independent of any single recipient's history of interaction.

The two programs share a general concern with how recipients come to accept AI-mediated outputs, but they are methodologically independent: Research I's conceptual architecture (Behavior, Attribution, Acceptance, and related elements) is not assumed to map onto Research II's five functions or five authorities, and no finding from either program is treated as a precondition for the other's validity.

7.2 The Boundary Question RQ-D1

The explicit boundary question formulated in Section 6.4 — how the structural distribution of authority over representations affects the recipient's epistemic standards examined in Research I — is retained as a question about the possible intersection of the two programs, not as an integration of them. Pursuing RQ-D1 would require both programs to have reached a stage at which their respective findings, rather than their architectures alone, could be meaningfully related. At the time of this manuscript, neither program has produced empirical findings; RQ-D1 is therefore recorded as a later-priority question (Section 6.5) and is not pursued further here.

7.3 Methodological Scope: Deferred

Whether the questions in families A through C are examined through document and policy analysis, through empirical study of specific AI-mediated systems, through a combination of the two, or through some other method, is not determined by this manuscript. The program's own discipline, established in the Conceptual Architecture (Section 3.1), is to avoid fixing methodology before the architecture it would operationalize has itself been adopted.

This deferral is a structural commitment, not an omission: fixing a methodology prematurely risks shaping the architecture to fit a convenient method rather than selecting a method appropriate to the architecture's own questions.

8. Research Governance and Document Status

8.1 Sequential Adoption

The program's four foundational documents are developed and adopted sequentially, each depending on the documents before it:

1. Conceptual Architecture — depends on nothing prior; establishes the functional vocabulary.
2. Authority Structure — depends on the Conceptual Architecture; establishes the authority vocabulary.
3. Representation Lifecycle — depends on both prior documents; establishes the stages and paths.
4. Research Questions — depends on all three prior documents; formulates the questions these documents make askable.

No further architectural work, no platform or system selection, and no methodological commitments proceed from a given document until it is adopted. This sequencing is a governance discipline carried over directly from the source documents and is preserved unmodified in this manuscript.

8.2 Current Document Status

Document	Version	Status
Conceptual Architecture	0.2	Adopted
Authority Structure	0.1	Pending adoption
Representation Lifecycle	0.1	Pending adoption
Research Questions	0.1	Pending adoption

After adoption of all four documents, the program will determine its methodological scope (RQ-D2, Section 6.4) and proceed accordingly.

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9. Limitations

Several limitations apply to the program at its present stage.

1. Three of the four foundational documents (Authority Structure, Representation Lifecycle, Research Questions) remain at version 0.1 and are not yet adopted; conclusions drawn from them should be treated as provisional pending adoption.
2. The literature review has not been conducted (Section 2); the architecture's relationship to existing frameworks in platform studies, media sociology, and algorithmic governance research is not yet established, and no claim of conceptual originality is made.
3. No systems have been examined under this protocol; the five functional units, five authorities, six lifecycle stages, and five alternative paths are analytical proposals, not empirically validated categories.
4. The methodological scope of the program (analytical, empirical, or combined) is explicitly undetermined (Section 7.3); this manuscript cannot specify what kind of evidence will ultimately bear on the research questions in Section 6.
5. The boundary relation to Research I (RQ-D1) is recorded but not pursued; no claim is made that the two programs' findings will in fact prove related.
6. The five functional units, five authorities, and six lifecycle stages are presented as a coherent architecture, but their mutual consistency and non-redundancy have not been independently audited beyond the internal cross-references given in Sections 3 through 5.

10. Conclusion

This manuscript has consolidated the four foundational documents of Research II into a single research protocol examining the structural production and control of representations encountered through AI-mediated systems. The Conceptual Architecture distinguishes five functional units defined by function rather than ownership; the Authority Structure distinguishes five authority types and establishes that authority is analytically distinct from function; the Representation Lifecycle traces six stages and six structurally distinct paths, including a canonical path offered only as a reference point; and the Research Questions formulate twenty research questions across four families, sequenced by their dependency on one another.

The program's governing discipline throughout is negative as much as constructive: it specifies what is not assumed — that functions have distinct owners, that authorities are concentrated, that the canonical lifecycle path is typical, that interruptions are failures, or that a particular methodology is required — at least as carefully as it specifies the categories themselves.

Three of the program's four foundational documents remain pending adoption, no literature review has yet situated the architecture against existing scholarship, and no empirical or analytical examination of specific systems has been undertaken. This manuscript therefore presents an architecture and a research protocol, not findings. Its contribution, at this stage, is the specification of a vocabulary and a set of questions precise enough to be tested against actual AI-mediated systems once the program's methodological scope is determined.

References

Status: *Pending literature review and source verification.*

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The reference list will be constructed after the planned literature review (Section 2) is completed. One internal reference, to the program's own prior output, is recorded below because it is directly invoked in Section 6.4 and Section 7 as the subject of a boundary research question, not as external literature.

1. Baladi, S. (2026). **Epistemic Discipline in the Age of Artificial Intelligence: A Three-Study Research Protocol** (Version 1.0.0) [Research I]. Zenodo. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23876902

No other reference is included in this initial manuscript draft pending the literature review.

Research Status Statement

Research II — The Production and Control of Representations in Artificial Intelligence

Component	Current status
Research problem	Specified
Central research question	Specified
Conceptual Architecture	Adopted (v0.2)
Authority Structure	Specified; pending adoption (v0.1)
Representation Lifecycle	Specified; pending adoption (v0.1)
Research Questions (20 questions, 4 families)	Specified; pending adoption (v0.1)
Literature review	Not conducted
Methodological scope	Deferred (RQ-D2)
Boundary relation to Research I	Recorded (RQ-D1); not pursued
Systems examined	None
Empirical or analytical findings	Not available
Theoretical originality	Not established

Reference State

Research II / Conceptual Architecture / v0.2 — Adopted

Research II / Authority Structure / v0.1 — Pending Adoption

Research II / Representation Lifecycle / v0.1 — Pending Adoption

Research II / Research Questions / v0.1 — Pending Adoption

Manuscript designation: Initial Program Manuscript — Version 0.1

Record ID: RES-II-REPR-01 · Version: 0.1 · DOI: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23940837
Scope: Prospective structural research protocol — conceptual, authority, and lifecycle architecture · Empirical baseline: Not yet executed.
Next Research Stage: Adoption of the Authority Structure, Representation Lifecycle, and Research Questions documents; literature review; determination of methodological scope.

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